

Course guide

How this course is built, and how you will be assessed. First assessment 2028.

1. What is DP History?

DP History is a dynamic, evidence-based, interpretative discipline that engages with the past. The course does not ask you to simply memorize what happened — it asks you to think historically: to inquire, to weigh evidence, to compare perspectives, and to reach your own reasoned judgements. In the language of the official curriculum model, you are invited not to “study history” but to “do history.”

It is a world history course: a mixture of comparative, thematic and in-depth studies drawn from global, regional and national contexts, built to balance structure with flexibility.

By the end of the course, you will be able to:

- Explore and critically engage with multiple perspectives and ways of thinking
- Investigate and evaluate the interactions between individuals and societies
- Think and act as informed and principled individuals in societies
- Understand and value the variety and diversity of the human experience across time and place

2. How the course is organized

The curriculum is built from four parts, all connected through historical inquiry at the centre: **contexts** (which situate content), **concepts** (which focus the inquiry), **content** (chosen from a wide range of options) and **skills** (which support the inquiry in practice).

The four contexts

Context	SL hours	HL hours	What you choose
Focused study	50	50	Choose 1 of 5 options, each with 2 focused studies (both studied)
Thematic study	80	80	Choose 1 of 4 options
Regional study	—	90	HL only. Choose 1 region, then 2 studies from it
Historical investigation	20	20	Internal assessment — independent research

Total teaching hours: 150 at SL, 240 at HL.

The four concepts

Every focused, thematic and regional study is examined through the same four historical concepts: **cause and consequence**, **continuity and change**, **perspectives**, and **significance**. These are not add-ons — Paper 2, Section A assesses them directly, and every essay or source response is expected to engage with at least one of them explicitly.

3. How you are assessed

Assessment is organized around six elements — inquiry contexts, concepts, sources, content, arguments, and inquiry questions — each assessed at three depths: knowledge and understanding, application and analysis, and evaluation and synthesis. In practice, this plays out across three written papers and one internal assessment.

Standard Level

Component	Weight	Format	What it covers
Paper 1	30%	1h 15m · 24 marks	Source-based, on the focused studies. 3 questions on one overarching inquiry question.
Paper 2	40%	1h 45m · 25 marks	Section A: concepts (choose 1 of 2). Section B: thematic study — short response + essay.
Internal assessment	30%	20h · 24 marks	Historical investigation — your own research question, sources and argument.

Higher Level

Component	Weight	Format	What it covers
Paper 1	20%	1h 15m · 24 marks	Same as SL.
Paper 2	25%	1h 45m · 25 marks	Same as SL.
Paper 3	35%	2h · 30 marks	Regional study essays. 2 questions, each from a different regional study.
Internal assessment	20%	20h · 24 marks	Same as SL.

Command terms you will meet

The official sample questions released with this syllabus use these command terms. Each tells you what kind of thinking the question wants:

Term	What it asks you to do
Explain	Give reasons for something, using evidence to support the reasoning.
Analyse	Break something down to show how its parts relate and what that reveals.
Examine	Consider an argument or event closely, from more than one angle.
To what extent	Weigh up a claim and reach a reasoned, evidenced judgement on how far you agree.

A note on sources. This guide is built directly from the official IB DP History Subject Brief (first assessment 2028). The Subject Brief is a public summary, not the complete Subject Guide — so the full prescribed content lists, the complete command-term glossary, and the official markbands are not yet reflected here. This guide will be extended once the full Subject Guide is available.